**Combat rule** – Underwater combat · SRD 5.2.1

Underwater, **melee attacks** by creatures without a **swim speed** have **disadvantage**, except with a dagger, javelin, shortsword, spear or trident. **Ranged attacks** automatically miss beyond normal range, and have **disadvantage** within it (except crossbow, net, thrown javelin).

Creatures **fully immersed** have **fire resistance**.

### 🎲 Quick summary:

1. Melee without a swim speed: **disadvantage** (except 5 weapons).
2. Ranged: **miss** beyond normal range.
3. Immersed: **fire resistance**.
4. Swimming: **1 extra foot** per foot without a swim speed.

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### ⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 reuses the 2014 underwater combat rules.

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### ⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn't say how long you can hold your breath in combat. Fix: 1 + Con modifier minutes (30 seconds minimum), then suffocation.

### 💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe filtering light, muffled sounds and slowed movements.

## Step 1 – Check:

Does the creature have a swim speed?

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## Step 2 – Melee:

Disadvantage, except dagger, javelin, shortsword, spear or trident.

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## Step 3 – Ranged:

Miss beyond normal range; disadvantage within it, except crossbow, net, javelin.

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## Step 4 – Fire:

Immersed creatures have fire resistance.

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## Step 5 – Breath:

See the table: after the breath time, Con rounds remain before 0 HP.

*Example: Brann (no swim speed) strikes with a mace underwater: disadvantage. With a trident, no penalty.*

| Stage | Duration |
|---|---|
| Holding your breath | 1 + Con mod. minutes (min. 30 seconds) |
| Out of breath | Con mod. rounds (min. 1) |
| Then | Drops to 0 HP and dies at the start of the next turn |
| Spells | Water Breathing removes suffocation |

## ⚠ Common questions:

### Which weapons have no penalty?

Dagger, javelin, shortsword, spear, trident.

### Does a bow work?

It misses beyond normal range and has disadvantage within it.

### And the crossbow?

No disadvantage within normal range.

### What about fire?

Resistance to fire damage.

### What does swimming cost?

1 extra foot per foot, without a swim speed.

### How long can I hold my breath?

1 + Con minutes, 30 seconds minimum.

## ⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

### Fire spells

Do fire spells work? **Option**: yes, with resistance.

### Visibility

Murky water: reduced visibility. **Option**: lightly obscured.

### Armor

Does heavy armor sink you? **Option**: no, unless the DM says.

## ⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

### Bow

It keeps normal range only, with disadvantage.

### Breath

See the suffocation table.

### Swimming

A swim speed removes all penalties.

*These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.*

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